

Expert Session Summary

Session conducted by Dr. Bazeer Hussain

MANO 2026 – Kerala's First Psychology Students' Conclave

Quick Brief Summary

In a lecture on substance use and mental health by Dr. Bazeer Hussain, the causes of substance addiction, withdrawal symptoms, the possibilities of relapse, and the connection with ADHD are explained. The session also emphasizes the importance of comprehensive history-taking in diagnosis and the participation of family members.

Detailed Summary

Introduction

This is a summary of the session titled 'Diagnosis and Management of Substance Use Disorder', led by Dr. Bazeer Hussain (MD Psychiatry, CEO & Consultant Psychiatrist, Sereniche Academy, Futureace Hospital). Eschewing lengthy formal introductions, the speaker presented the topic through real case studies and practical experiences that psychology students and clinical practitioners frequently encounter. The session elaborates on how a therapist should understand and manage the use of substances like alcohol and drugs, along with their complexities.

Main Theme: Substance Use and Mental Health

The speaker asserts that Substance Use Disorder is not merely a habit, but a complex condition affecting brain functions. The central themes of this lecture are the importance of history-taking, the underlying causes behind substance use (such as conditions like ADHD), and 'relapse', the state where patients slip back into their old habits.

Key Areas Explored

The First Case and Relapse

The speaker presents the case of a 35-year-old individual who had worked as a security officer in Qatar and later had to return to his home country. He resumed drinking alcohol, which he had quit for years, during a party he hosted for friends in celebration of his wife's childbirth. An important truth that therapists must understand is that 'Relapse is a dictum'. This means that individuals who quit substances have a very high likelihood of returning to their previous state. Therapists should not feel discouraged by this and need to continue supporting the patient. The speaker also emphasizes the importance of the patient seeking treatment during the 'lapse' stage—a minor slip before a full relapse.

Withdrawal and Delirium

Patients often approach psychologists before seeing a psychiatrist. Therefore, therapists must have the knowledge to recognize 'Withdrawal Symptoms' that occur when alcohol or other substances are abruptly stopped. Alcohol withdrawal symptoms can lead to seizures and subsequently to 'Delirium' (Acute Confusory/Confusion Stage), a state of disorientation regarding time and place. Since this is life-threatening, medical management with the help of a psychiatrist and Motivation Enhancement Therapy (MET) must be provided in a timely manner.

The Link Between Stimulants and ADHD

Describing the case of a 38-year-old businessman, the speaker explains the use of stimulants and its consequences. He used substances to gain high energy and business growth, but later slipped into mental health issues including paranoia/psychosis. Often, such substance use is underpinned by Attention Deficit Hyperactivity Disorder (ADHD) dating back to childhood. Because dopamine levels are not satisfactory under normal conditions, such individuals seek intense experiences. Therefore, gathering a comprehensive childhood history is crucial for diagnosis.

Cannabis Use and Cultural Shifts

The speaker also addresses the widespread use of cannabis in society. When the THC content in cannabis is artificially increased and converted into hybrid forms, it severely impacts the brain. There is a growing trend of

using cannabis as a remedy for insomnia and depression. However, the speaker reminds therapists to be prepared to ask direct questions without hesitation or fear to those who use substances.

Key Insights: Essential Recommendations for Professional Practice

Importance of History Taking: Comprehensive history-taking is indispensable for treatment success. Maximum information must be gathered from the patient's family members and relatives.

View Relapse as Natural: Understand that relapse is common in substance treatment, and therapists should not feel defeated by it, but rather be ready to help the patient get back on their feet.

Follow ICD-11 Guidelines: It is imperative to read and understand the World Health Organization's ICD-11 or DSM criteria for diagnosis.

Multidisciplinary Approach: Since substance use affects not just the individual but also the family and society, treatment methods that include family members (Multidisciplinary Approach) must be implemented.

Conclusion: Challenges and Potentials of Clinical Psychology

The speaker concludes that while treating those affected by substance use and mental health issues is challenging, it is a deeply fulfilling field for a therapist. With accurate academic knowledge, in-depth training, and patience, it is possible to reclaim the lives of those caught in the grip of substance abuse. The lecture ends by emphasizing the need for psychology students to gain deep knowledge in this field, especially at a time when substance use is increasing in society.

Highlights

Relapse in Substance Use Disorder is a Reality

Relapse refers to a person who has completely stopped substance use returning to their old habits. This is something that can potentially happen during treatment. Therapists should not feel discouraged by this, but rather continue to support the patient, and educate both the family and the patient in advance, anticipating that a relapse may occur.

The Importance of Comprehensive History Taking

Accurate history taking is the most crucial aspect in the diagnosis of patients with substance use disorder. Detailed history taking helps uncover childhood information, family background, the reason for substance use, and other mental health issues (such as ADHD, depression).

The Connection Between Substance Use and ADHD

Attention deficit and hyperactivity (ADHD) are commonly found in many individuals who excessively use stimulants. When the naturally available dopamine levels are not enough, these individuals turn to intense substances and stimulants. Therefore, ADHD must also be screened for in such cases. Workshop conducted by Dr. Benzir Hussain.

Withdrawal Symptoms and Management

It is essential to recognize the withdrawal symptoms that occur as a result of suddenly stopping substance use (for example, seizures and delirium in alcohol withdrawal). These must be identified in a timely manner, and medical management with the help of a psychiatrist along with Motivational Enhancement Therapy (MET) should be provided.